

WORLD'S SURFACE

The world's land surface is under constant attack from heat, wind, water, ice, and the sea. These forces gradually shape and rearrange Earth's landscape over many years, sculpting rocks into weird and wonderful shapes, breaking them up, and moving the debris from one place to another.

Wadi—a narrow gorge carved by rare flash floods

Mesa—a flat-topped desert mountain

Heat erosion

Most deserts are bare rock, which is sculpted by the combined effects of extreme temperatures and strong winds to create dramatic desert landscapes.

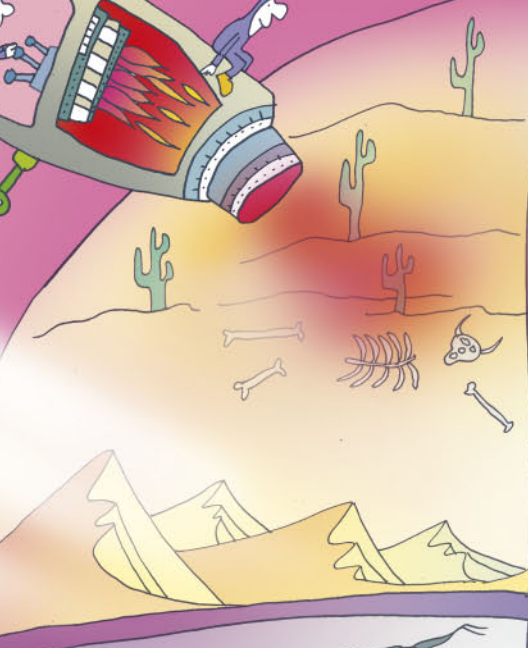
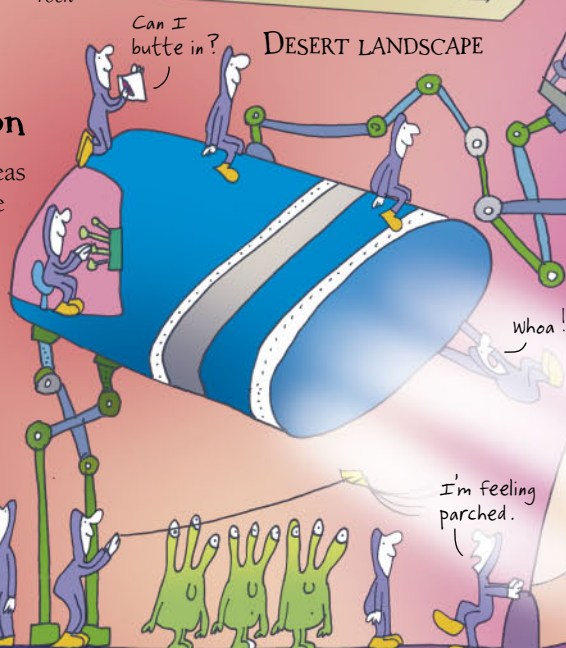
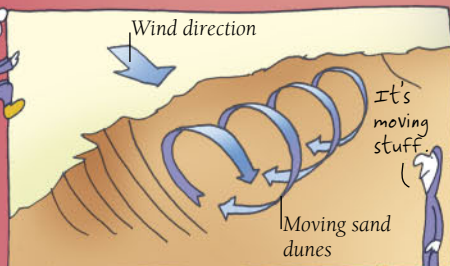
Butte—an isolated peak of rock

This subject's a little dry.

Wind erosion

Some deserts, such as the Sahara, have vast areas of sand that are blown by the wind into huge sand dunes. With little vegetation to hold them in place, the sand dunes move across the desert, constantly changing its landscape.

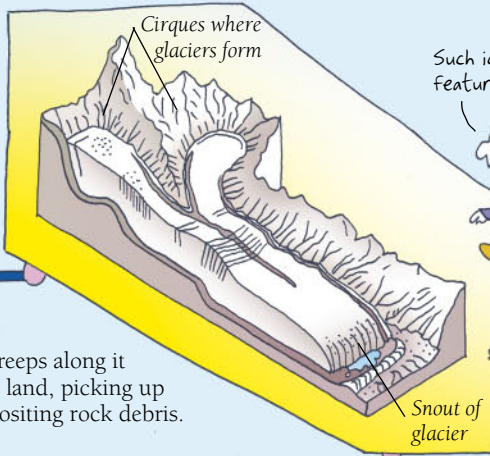
DESERT LANDSCAPE



Ice erosion

At the Poles and in the mountains, large areas of land are covered by ice. Some of this ice moves downhill as a frozen river or glacier, cutting into the land and carving out great U-shaped valleys.

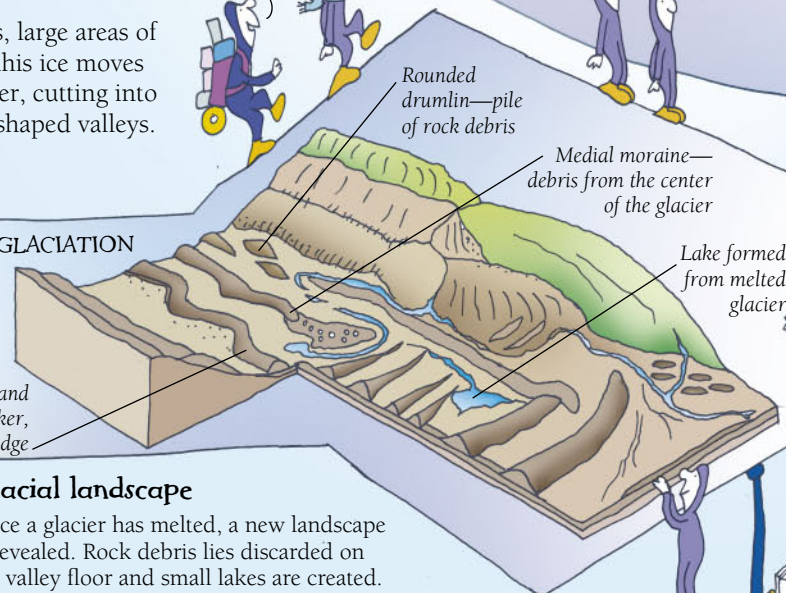
FEATURES OF A GLACIER



Glaciers

As a glacier creeps along it bulldozes the land, picking up and then depositing rock debris.

AFTER GLACIATION



Glacial landscape

Once a glacier has melted, a new landscape is revealed. Rock debris lies discarded on the valley floor and small lakes are created.